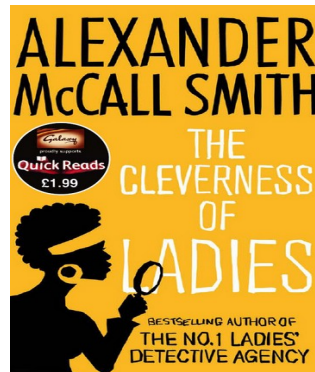


The Cleverness of Ladies by Alexander McCall Smith

Introduction

- You are going to read a short extract from a book to help you practise your reading skills.
- Look at the title and front cover of the book.
- What do you think it is about?



Little, Brown (Quick Reads)

- Here are some words from the story. Who do you think the story is about?

Tlokweng Road Speedy Motors
Mma Ramotswe
 mechanic marriage **No.1 Ladies' Detective Agency**
 detective **Mr.J.L.B.Matekoni**

Activity 1

Look at the transcript of the first 200 words of the story (below) and read it for 1 minute and 20 seconds. Mark where you read up to.

Go back to the beginning of the story and read for another minute and 20 seconds. Mark where you read up to again. You should be able to read further on this second reading.

Continue timing yourself reading until you have read the whole text.

The Cleverness of Ladies – Transcript

1	It was a slack time at the No. 1 Ladies' Detective Agency, the only detective agency in
2	Botswana. It would be wrong to say that nothing was going on – Mma Ramotswe, who
3	had founded the agency to deal with the problems of ladies (and others), knew that
4	something was always happening. People were always getting themselves into
5	unfortunate scrapes; they had always done this, and human nature showed no sign of
6	changing. No, the reason why things were quiet was that nobody was bringing anything to
7	the attention of the small detective agency at the back of Tlokweng Road Speedy Motors.
8	The garage business was owned by Mma Ramotswe's husband, Mr. J.L.B. Matekoni, who
9	everyone agreed was the finest mechanic in Botswana. She had been engaged to Mr.
10	J.L.B. Matekoni for rather a long time, and eventually he had married her. But some say this
11	was only as a result of clever plotting by the cunning matron of the Tlokweng Orphan
12	Farm, Mma Potokwani.
13	Yet such a view was uncharitable. Mr J.L.B. Matekoni was sometimes a bit indecisive,
14	and marriage proved to be only one of the things that he was indecisive about.

Activity 2

Vocabulary – similar meanings

Match the words and phrases from the story to similar meanings. You could use a dictionary to help you.

Word or phrase from the story	Similar meaning
a mechanic	not many customers; business is slow
uncharitable	feelings and behaviour typical of most people
a slack time	someone whose job is to discover information about crimes
cunning	not kind
a scrape	describes someone who uses clever tricks or cheats to get what they want
indecisive	someone whose job is to repair machines e.g. cars
human nature	not able to make a decision
a detective	a difficult or dangerous situation

Activity 3

True / False / No information

Look at the selected passage of *The Cleverness of Ladies* by Alexander McCall Smith and decide whether the following statements are true **(T)**, false **(F)**, or if there is no information **(NI)**.

1. The Ladies' Detective agency is very busy.
2. There is only one detective agency in Botswana.
3. The Ladies' Detective agency is only for women.
4. The agency is based at the back of a garage.
5. Tlokweng Road Speedy Motors is owned by Mr J.L.B. Matekoni.
6. Mma Ramotswe has been married for a long time.
7. Mr Matekoni is a terrible mechanic.
8. The Detective agency is big.
9. There is nothing going on in Botswana.

Activity 4

In this activity, you can check your understanding of the story.

Match the beginnings and endings to see if you can correctly complete the sentences from the story.

Beginning	End
It was a slack time	was that nobody was bringing anything to the attention of the small detective agency.
It would be wrong to say	Mr. J.L.B Matekoni
People were always getting themselves	that nothing was going on.
The reason why things were quiet	for rather a long time.
The garage business was owned by Mma Ramotswe's husband	into unfortunate scrapes.
She had been engaged to Mr. J.L.B. Matekoni	and marriage proved to be only one of the things that he was indecisive about.
Mr. J.L.B Matekoni was sometimes a bit indecisive,	at the No.1 Ladies' Detective Agency.

Activity 5

Put the words in order to make a sentence, or part of a sentence, that appears in the text.

1. was a time at No.1 Ladies' Detective Agency. slack It the

2. always into scrapes. unfortunate People getting were themselves

3. husband the was Mma. Ramotswe's garage owned business by

4. time she engaged been for Mr J.L.B Maketoni had to long a

5. married had eventually her he

- Now you have completed all of the activities, try reading the whole text again.
- As you read the text, listen to someone reading the text aloud.
- Try to read at the same speed as the speaker.

Reading regularly for pleasure in English will benefit you in many ways:

- It will improve your vocabulary, introducing you to words you may not have heard before.
- It will improve your writing skills – by spending time reading in English you will also be learning how grammar works.
- It will improve your spelling and memory.
- It will help you learn about a variety of cultures and the way things work in different parts of the world.
- It will help you to develop your general knowledge, giving you new topics for conversation.
- It will help you to relax, giving you some quiet time.
- It is fun!

To find out what happens next in 'The Cleverness of Ladies', you can order a copy of the book for yourself. Go to:

<http://www.quickreads.org.uk/content/cleverness-ladies>

You could also ask for the book at your local library.

What do you think about this book? If you read it, let us know what you think.

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<http://www.quickreads.org.uk/>



Answers

Activity 2 – Vocabulary – similar meanings

a mechanic - someone whose job is to repair machines e.g. cars

uncharitable - not kind

a slack time - not many customers; business is slow

cunning - describes someone who uses clever tricks or cheats to get what they want

a scrape - a difficult or dangerous situation

indecisive - not able to make a decision

human nature - feelings and behaviour typical of most people

a detective - someone whose job is to discover information about crimes

Activity 3 – True, false, or unsure

1. The Ladies' Detective agency is very busy. **False.**
2. There is only one detective agency in Botswana. **True.**
3. The Ladies' Detective agency is only for women. **False.**
4. The agency is based at the back of a garage. **True.**
5. Tlokweng Road Speedy Motors is owned by Mr J.L.B. Matekoni. **True.**
6. Mma Ramotswe has been married for a long time. **No information.**
7. Mr Matekoni is a terrible mechanic. **False.**
8. The Detective agency is big. **False.**
9. There is nothing going on in Botswana. **False.**

Activity 4

It was a slack time	at the No.1 Ladies' Detective Agency.
It would be wrong to say	that nothing was going on.
People were always getting themselves	into unfortunate scrapes.
The reason why things were quiet	was that nobody was bringing anything to the attention of the small detective agency.
The garage business was owned by Mma Ramotswe's husband	Mr. J.L.B Matekoni.
She had been engaged to Mr. J.L.B. Matekoni	for rather a long time.
Mr. J.L.B Matekoni was sometimes a bit indecisive,	and marriage proved to be only one of the things that he was indecisive about.

Activity 5

1. It was a slack time at the No. Ladies' Detective Agency.
2. People were always getting themselves into unfortunate scrapes.
3. The garage business was owned by Mma. Ramotswe's husband.
4. She had been engaged to Mr J.L.B. Maketoni for rather a long time.
5. Eventually he had married her.